

COURSE FILE

PC722: Fundamentals of Design - I (Drawing, Observation & Composition)

Credit Structure: 3-0-4-5

Program: MDes (Communication Design)

Year: 1

Semester: 1

Duration: 18 Days (Full Day – Lecture + Studio)

Timing: 9 AM – 6 PM

Course Instructor: Anirban Dutta Gupta + Visiting Faculty

Couse Placement: Core course for MDes (CD) Semester 1. This course is composed of two parts – part A: Drawing and Observation and Part B: Composition. Part A and Part B is taken consecutively. This is a foundational course in design.

Course Format: Module based. The course is taught as a combination of Lectures and Studio sessions. Lectures introduce concepts, which are then analysed and explored via studio sessions and assignments. Lecture and studio is integrated and in certain cases can overlap. Teaching is through hand-on learning and through learning-by-doing and via real-time demonstrations and guidance by faculty members.

Course Objective and Content:

Design is an interdisciplinary activity – characterized by the constant preoccupation of co-relating disciplines, dealing with and trying to understand the complex and interesting worlds of the physical, biological, imaginary, and human, all of which are multivariate in character. 'The Fundamentals of Design 1' course is an attempt to sensitize you to this complex, dynamic and multidimensional scenario – to expand the focus of your discipline, and place you within the larger context and discourse of design. The main objective of this

module is to acquaint students with the means and methods of approaching, investigating and solving problems creatively by providing them with appropriate design and conceptual skill sets – one such primary skill being that of ‘Drawing and Observation’ and ‘Composition’.

Drawing and observation are fundamental to design because they are the primary tools for understanding and translating the world around us. They help designers move from abstract ideas to concrete, viable solutions. Observation is the bedrock of the design process. It's about more than just looking; it's about seeing, and it's about a mindful, purposeful study of people, objects, and environments. By observing users in their natural habitats, designers can gain empathy and uncover unspoken needs, pain points, and behaviors that people may not even realize they have. This direct insight is crucial for creating designs that are truly user-centred. Observation also helps designers to gather data, identify opportunities by noticing what is and what is not working and find inspiration through observing nature, art, and daily life that can spark new ideas and creative connections between disparate concepts.

Following on from observation, Drawing is the language of design. It's not about creating a perfect piece of art, but about a practical tool for thinking and communicating. Drawing gives shape to abstract ideas, allowing designers to quickly externalize and refine their thoughts. As a critical skill drawing helps in visual thinking and work through problems, explore multiple solutions, and develop ideas rapidly. It's far faster and more flexible than using digital tools in the early stages of a project.

The act of drawing forces you to look at a subject more closely, paying attention to details like proportion, form, light, and texture. This trains your eye to see the world with a designer's perspective. By adding a layer of critical and reflexive thinking, drawing becomes a tool for communication – a rapid way to visually communicate the idea, something that is visual and tangible, which otherwise would be challenging to use words to communicate.

While Part A: Drawing and observation trains the eye to see and the hand to represent, Part B: Composition introduces the critical process of strategically arranging of elements to create a cohesive, clear, and impactful message. A good composition helps one control how a user's eye moves through a design, ensuring they see the most important information first. Without it, a design can feel chaotic, cluttered, and confusing, making it difficult for users to understand its purpose. Composition relies on several key cognitive principles (for example the Gestalt Theory) that work together to create an effective design. Composition looks at visual hierarchy which is the order in which a viewer's eye is drawn to elements. One can create a visual hierarchy by adjusting size, colour, contrast, and position to make some elements stand out more than others. Using the broad concepts of visual balance, contrast, rhythm and harmony and integrating with concepts of proximity and repetition the design can be perceived as a structured group. By grouping related items, one makes information easier to scan and understand. By using consistent elements like a specific colour palette, typography, or spacing, the design creates a sense of unity and reinforces a communication and identity, making the design feel cohesive and professional. By integrated negative space (or White Space) it gives the user's eye a place to rest, prevents the design from feeling cluttered, and can be used to emphasize a focal point by isolating it from other elements.

For any design, whether digital interfaces or analog products, composition directly impacts user experience. It determines whether a user can quickly find what they're looking for and accomplish a task. A good composition increases comprehension with a well-composed design reducing cognitive load. The visual hierarchy guides them, making the information easy to process. It also improves usability by creating intuitive layouts. This leads to higher conversion rates, lower bounce rates, and a more pleasant experience for the user.

Beyond function, a good composition is simply more visually appealing. It creates a sense of harmony and professionalism that builds trust and makes the user want to engage with the design.

This module emphasizes the latitude and value of individual thinking and one's ability to observe and see, which would enable you to apply yourself creatively in solving problems. Composition in design terms is defined as structured, thoughtful, compatible placement or arrangements of elements in space (2-dimension/3-dimension/4-dimension) and/or time. Composition allows us to incorporate varied elements, combining them into reasonable and working whole – an example that can be referred to here can be that of cooking – by combining varied elements in a particular manner and in particular proportions it produces a palatable preparation. Good composition conveys information, tells a story, draws attention to the important and useful bits, segregates data, brings in elements of aesthetics and leaves an indelible imprint in the mind's eye.

This is a critical foundational course in design.

Course Outcomes:

Knowledge:

1. Observation of objects, nature, indoor, outdoor
2. Observation and imagination
3. Hand, eye, perception
4. Representation, Perspective & Proportion
5. 1-point, 2-point & 3-point perspective
6. Analytical and isometric drawings
7. Human sketching and capturing motion
8. Distilling to capture the essence
9. Composition and its rules
10. Principles of Composition: Balance, Contrast, Harmony, Rhythm, Repetition, Proximity, Negative Space, Figure-ground
11. Gestalt Theory and its application
12. Application of Gestalt Laws
13. Nature of 2D and 3D spaces
14. Composition in the real world

Skill:

1. Drawing & Sketching skills
2. Understanding tools – pencil, pen, paper, ink, brush
3. Quality, precision and professionalism
4. Visualisation and eye-trace training
5. Judgement
6. Communication
7. Reflexive thinking

Assessment Method: Continuous assessment of application of concepts through the duration of the course, along with assessment of group and individual assignments given. Assessment will not only cover the assignments, but professionalism, precision, pride, care and discipline displayed by the students.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8	P9	P10	P11	P12
	X	X	X	X		X	X	X	X	X	X

Course Outcome: The course aims to equip the students with professional knowledge – creative, narrative and technical – on the fundamental building blocks of design approach – that of observation, representation and composition. This course prepares the students for professional application of these basic guidelines which will be applied in all design fields going forward.

Growth Matrix:

Flow	Objectives
1	Exercise 1.1: Understanding tools

	Objective: To understand and appreciate the different tools and how they behave
2	Exercise 1.2: Observation & Sketching Objective: To see and perceive.
3	Exercise 1.3: Observation from nature Objective: To record ever changing conditions of nature.
4	Exercise 1.4: Perspective Objective: Understand the different forms of perspective and how to record them in a 2D space.
5	Exercise 1.5: Human drawing Objective: Understanding proportions, posture, movement, shape and form of Human figures and how they are perceived in space.
6	Exercise 2.1: Principles of composition: In a 20cm x 20cm square articulate the following elements of composition: Balance, contrast, Rhythm, Harmony, Motion, Pattern, Focus, proportion using the following elements of composition: - lines - blocks (using shapes Square, triangle & circle) - Newspaper cutouts (only text not images) Objective: To understand principles of composition.
7	Exercise 2.2: Organisational aspects (Gestalt rules) of composition: In a 20cm x 20cm square articulate the following organisation aspects of composition: Similarity, Continuation, Closure, Proximity, Figure-ground, symmetry & order using the following elements: - blocks (using shapes Square, triangle & circle) - On digital platform using vector software

	Objective: To understand organisational aspect of composition.
8	Exercise 2.3: Choose a magazine spread or poster of your liking and analyse the elements of composition. Explore to see if you can rearrange the elements to create a new composition. You can scan the spread/image and replicate the elements in photoshop/vector software for your exploration. Objective: To understand and appreciate how composition rules are used in 2D space
9	Exercise 2.4: Follow on from Exercise 2: Use your mobile camera to shoot images off campus that communicate the following aspects of composition: Similarity, Continuation, Closure, Proximity, Figure-ground, symmetry & order. Objective: To understand composition in the real world and to train your eyes to see it
10	Exercise 2.5: Observe a complex place (Pani-puri vendors, shopping mall, lotus pond etc) and try and understand how different elements work. Identify the key elements, how they work, the hierarchy between them and find a suitable way to present it. Objective: To appreciate that design and composition permeates all aspects of life around.
11	Exercise 2.6: Choose one artwork from your Exercise 4 and replicate that in 3 D space. Use paper to create a box (minimum dimensions 20 x 20 cm) and place the elements in the space to replicate the chosen artwork. Objective: To understand composition in space and how elements behave in

	relation to each other when placed in depth.
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Some things to keep in mind:

- Attendance is mandatory. You will have to be present during class hours.
- All assignments have to be completed.
- Use of any form of AI tools to generate concepts is strictly forbidden unless discussed in class and allowed for the specific assignment.

Reference:

- *Ways of Seeing* by John Berger
- *Drawing on the Right Side of the Brain* by Betty Edwards
- *How to Draw: Drawing and Sketching Objects and Environments from Your Imagination* by Scott Robertson
- *Grid Systems in Graphic Design* by Josef Müller-Brockmann
- *Making and Breaking the Grid: A Graphic Design Layout Workshop* by Timothy Samara
- *The Elements of Graphic Design* by Alex W. White
- *A Designer's Art* by Paul Rand